

Menu

Tampa Bay Times

ADVERTISEMENT

INVESTIGATIONS

They went to the Dozier School for Boys damaged. They came out destroyed.

Read the classic Tampa Bay Times story that
k chapter of Florida history.



n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



woods not far from t
with 31 unmarked
think the bodies of children murdered by guards at the Florida School for
of the graves can be at ed to students killed in a 1914 fire. Others c
swept the campus, but not all are accounted for.



By **Ben Montgomery** *Times Correspondent*
Waveney Ann Moore *Former Times Reporter*

Published Aug. 18, 2019 | Updated Aug. 18, 2019

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



winning series that resulted in the unearthing of dozens of previously unidentified graves. The Dozier school would close in 2011.

The men remember the same things: blood on the walls, bits of lip or tongue on the pillow, the smell of urine and whiskey, the way the bed springs sang with each blow. The way they cried out for Jesus or mama. The grinding of the old fan that muffled their cries. The one-armed man who swung the strap.

ADVERTISEMENT

They remember walking into the dark little building on the campus of the Florida School for Boys, in bare feet and white pajamas, afraid they'd never walk out.

For 109 years, this is where Florida has sent bad boys. Boys have been sent here for rape or assault, yes, but also for skipping school or smoking cigarettes or running hard from broken homes. Some were tough, some confused and afraid; all were treading through their formative years in the custody of the state. They were as young as 5, as old as 20, and they needed to be reformed.

It was for their own good.

... and scars on their backsides, carrying
and prison time a lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More
investigation into

lawsuit against a young old man. Now come the questions
What should be done?



Those questions have been asked again and again about the reform school at Marianna, where, for more than a century, boys went in damaged and came out destroyed.



EDMUND D. FOUNTAIN | Times The White House is visible on the campus of the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys in Marianna, FL. Former students claim they were horribly beaten by the school's staff within it's walls. The building was sealed by the state in October 2008 and a plaque placed on it

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

ADVERTISEMENT

^



In the late 1950s, a 13-year-old kid who slicked back his long hair like Elvis stood in front of a judge in Tampa. A car had been stolen from the neighborhood. Someone said they saw Willy Haynes driving it.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



neighborhood on Tampa's eastern edge, where a poor kid learned early how to protect himself. When the judge warned the boy to behave or he'd be sent to reform school in Marianna, Willy surprised the court.

Why can't I go now?

He had heard the Florida School for Boys had a band and a football team and maybe even Boy Scouts, and it didn't cost a penny to participate. He kissed his mother goodbye at the courthouse and left Tampa in the back of a state cruiser. Big, beautiful, oblivious Florida blurred by outside the window.

This was before the interstates sliced through the state, and they took Highway 41 north and connected with U.S. 19, then transferred to Highway 90 west, through Tallahassee, to the tiny panhandle town of Marianna.

Willy wasn't scared as the state car pulled onto the gravel road that led to the state's only boys' juvenile reformatory, the Florida School for Boys.

No fences. Manicured lawns. Tall pines and stately buildings. It looked like college. It had to be better than home.

ADVERTISEMENT

William Hayne



April 11, 1958.



The books were shelved in rows, and each was filled with names of hundreds of boys from across Florida. Some were man-sized boys with criminal records.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



A boy escorted Willy Haynes to Tyler Cottage and told him to keep his belongings in Locker No. 252. He was given a toothbrush and pajamas and his own military bunk. The poor kid from Tampa felt like he was finally home.

He was there barely a week when it happened. Some bullies caught him outside the showers, and the next thing he knew he was in the middle of a tangle of feet and fists. Willy knew how to fight, and he was choking one of his attackers in a headlock when a cottage father busted in.

The school's disciplinarian, R.W. Hatton, asked Willy who he had been fighting, but the boy would not give up the names. Better to be punished than be branded a puke.

You're going down, Hatton told him.

They dragged him across that manicured campus, toward the squat concrete building called the White House. They dragged him through the door.

Many boys sentenced to the school were severely abused by the staff in this building during the

building resemble a b' ...
ing an awful stench n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More
beaten. [Photo cour



ADVERTISEMENT



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



Here came Marshall Drawdy, Eddie Horne, Robert Lundy, Manuel Giddens . . .

And Jerry Cooper, snatched from his bed at midnight and dragged through the dark, bare feet over wet grass.

Shut your f----- mouth! one of the men told him. What do you know about a runner?

Just outside the door he saw a limp figure lying still. A boy. Blood on his pajamas.

And Larry Houston, Bryant Middleton, Donald Stratton . . .

And William Horne, waiting to go through the door when he heard a boy scream inside.

Then: I think we done killed him.

And Charles Rambo, George Goewey, James Griffin . . .

And Roger Kiser, a scrawny orphan. The stench hit him as he walked through the door. He tripped and fell and a man grabbed him and slung him on the bloody mattress. Over his shoulder, he could see that the man only had one arm.

Bite that nillow.

Henry Williams, . . .
rent cottages, di
circumstances ^ same destination.

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More



And Willy Haynes, who had asked the judge to send hi
throw a football under the pines. Over 18 months, the men dragged Willy into the White House again and again.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



Lay down. Hold the rail. Don't make a sound.

He could hear the strap coming. It started with the pivot, the shuffle of boots on concrete. The strap hit the wall, then the ceiling, then thighs and buttocks and back, and it felt like an explosion.

When he got back to the cottage, Willy stood in the shower and let the cold water wash bits of underwear from his lacerations, as his blood ran toward the drain.

The 2009 publication of the then-St. Petersburg Times' series on the Dozier School for Boys unearthed what so many knew for so long. [Times files]

The men gathered at the Florida School for Boys on Oct. 21, 2008.

and grandchild in their wallets. sprawling campus, they were fresh
w their hair was n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trun Read More
el beds. They can

Dick Colon had flown in from Baltimore, where he ow 
company. The 65-year-old was tormented by the memory of seeing a boy being
stuffed into an industrial dryer. Next to him stood Michael O'McCarthy, a writer
and political activist from Costa Rica, who was beaten so badly he was treated at

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



the end was a quiet man named Robert Straley, who sells glow lights and carnival novelties. He drove up from Clearwater. He had been having recurring nightmares of a man sitting on his bed.

Then there was Willy Haynes. He was 65 and went by Bill now. A tall, broad man, Haynes had worked for 30 years for the Alabama Department of Corrections. Haynes didn't feel good. There were plenty of places he'd rather be. But he knew he had to do this.

The men now called themselves the White House Boys.

In the past year, they had each searched online for information about the Florida School for Boys, for something that suggested they weren't the only ones burdened by their experience at the school. They had found Roger Kiser's Web site. Kiser added their memories and photos to his blog.

They approached the state, seeking official acknowledgement that they had been abused and hoping to find some resolution along the way.

They found a friend in Gus Barreiro of the state Department of Juvenile Justice. He set up this ceremony to close and seal the White House. He even ordered a plaque to be mounted on the building:

In memory of the children who passed these doors, we acknowledge their

they have found some measure of peace

in loss': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

of the need to re

our children as help them seek a brighter future.



A small crowd gathered that Tuesday morning: state officials, television crews and newspaper reporters.



Bill Haynes approached the podium. He was nervous, but he tried to speak clearly.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



mentally scarred me.

When it was time, the men turned to go inside the White House. The reporters and photographers surged close.

Bill Haynes stood at the door and stared into the darkness. He had driven so far. He had to go in, to face as an adult whatever it was that haunted him.

He tried to step through the door.

His knees buckled.

Once the White House Boys told their stories in front of the cameras, other men came forward with other memories.

George Goewey heard about the newspaper story at a St. Petersburg Starbucks. He remembered how the one-armed man would swing from down low, and how the strap would hit the ceiling, and how you could time the pain.

Eddie Horne was at work at a downtown St. Petersburg Publix when he saw the newspaper photograph of the White House. God's got a beating coming for the men who swung that strap, he says.

in the library, re
ne remembered
and died from
boy who was t



sure while hiding under a cottage. A
to the White House and never seen



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



EDMUND D. FOUNTAIN | Times A Times photographer casts a shadow on a tree in a swamp just south of the perimeter of the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys, formerly the Florida Industrial School for Boys. The school wasn't fenced initially, and many children tried to run away. To discourage this, some were told that the dogs would get them if they ran. If the dogs didn't get them, the swamp would.

Most of the men recalled being beaten by two staffers: R.W. Hatton and the one-armed man, Troy Tidwell. At least three men described being sexually abused by other guards in an underground room they called the rape room.

And there was something else. Newspapers had published a photograph of a small cemetery. Thirty-one white crosses. No names.

As stories of deaths and disappearances emerged from their collective memory, the White House Boys began to believe that they were the lucky ones.

When Troy Warren heard of the cemetery, his mind went back to his stay at the school. He says he and another boy were ordered to dig three holes behind the chow hall. They were to dig at night. Tidwell and another guard told them to make the holes 4 feet deep, and as long as a boy.

in Tampa, drift
fe had not been
Ed, died in Sep[^]ber 2004. He weighed heavy on her

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More



About 1 a.m., something made her sit up straight. Ther
what he had been talking about.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



seemed to his wife that he was reliving his childhood. He sat up at night for hours on end writing, filling pages of notebook paper.

After I saw these straps — long ones, thick ones, short ones — they reminded me of razor straps on the side of barber chairs. . . . I knew something horrible was going to happen to me. I was taken into a room and placed on a small bed about 3 ft wide, maybe 5 or 6 feet long. The bed was near the floor and had a filthy mattress on it. I was told to hold on to the end of the bed and not move or cry out. And then I remember the sound of something cutting the air, followed by a pain I can't describe. The most horrible pain a human being can imagine. It hurt so terribly bad. I would try and move to get up from the bed. God, Please make them stop beating me. But they beat me and beat me so bad.

He wrote of being beaten by the one-armed man.

I can't write anymore about this. God make them stop.

Night after night, while his family slept.

God please stop this! Please!!

Just before Ed slipped away, he scribbled a note for his wife and children, a last will and testament on notebook paper. He had two dying wishes.

... as he had recorded from cassette to ...
... he had been abu ... lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

Related story [Olson Whitehead's novel The N](#)
[from a real Florida story](#)



[Menu](#)

Tampa Bay Times



armed man, was still alive. He is named in the suit.

Gov. Charlie Crist called for an investigation into the graves. The Florida Department of Law Enforcement started pulling records and asking questions. They talked to Troy Warren, who remembers digging boy-sized holes.

How could this happen? How was this allowed to continue? Why didn't someone speak up sooner?

But people have been speaking out about the Florida School for Boys for more than 100 years.

The first scandal came in 1903, a mere three years after the school opened. Investigators found children “in irons, just as common criminals.” This was no reform school, their report said. This was a prison for children.

The investigation would launch a seemingly endless cycle of exposes and fleeting reform.

In its first two decades, investigators discovered that school administrators hired out boys to work with state convicts. They also learned that students were brutally beaten with a leather strap attached to a wooden handle.

when the fire started.

The superintendent lost his job.



Trouble continued with each passing year, from reports of inadequate medical care to the murder of two students by peers.

...s died trapped in loose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More
...and staff were in

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



stretched down dirt roads as people pattered through the campus, past waving mechanical Santas, plywood nativity scenes and angels with tinfoil wings.

By 1956, the overcrowded Marianna facility housed 698 students and 128 staffers. It had become the largest boys' school in the country, and it was growing.

A 1968 St. Petersburg Times photograph shows the overcrowding of beds in a cottage at the Florida School for Boys in Marianna, FL. Governor Claude Kirk toured the facility that year and found it in deplorable condition, claiming "If one of your kids were kept in such circumstance, you'd be up there with rifles." The photographs accompanied a Times article entitled "Hell's 1400 Acres." [Times (1968)]

In March 1958, a Miami psychologist and former staff member at the school told a U.S. Senate committee about mass beatings with a heavy, 3-1/2-inch-wide leather strap.

"The blows are very severe," Dr. Eugene Byrd testified. "They are dealt with a great deal of force with a full arm swing over his head and down, with a strap, a leather strap approximately a half-inch thick and about 10 inches long with a wooden formed handle."

d.

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

in my person... opinion it is brutality."



In 1968, corporal punishment was outlawed in state-run schools. The school had been renamed the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys, after a longtime superintendent. That year, Gov. Claude Kirk visited Marianna. He found holes in the leaking ceilings and broken walls, bucket toilets, bunk beds crammed together



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



"If one of your kids were kept in such circumstances," he said, "you'd be up there with rifles."

An official from the U.S. Department of Health called it a "monstrosity." One juvenile court judge who toured the facility vowed never again to send boys there. Another said it was so understaffed that boys were left alone at night and sexual perversion was common.

A year later, a reporter for the *Christian Science Monitor* visited the school and found a 16-year-old named Jim in solitary confinement. Jim had eaten a light bulb, then used a glass diffuser pried from a lighting fixture to gash his arm a dozen times from wrist to elbow.

"No one seemed to care," the reporter wrote. The headline read, Bulldoze them to the ground.

More reforms were ordered, administrators were replaced. A preacher began a ministry at the school. Staffers visited a successful juvenile program in Red Wing, Minn., and brought back lessons. Love, not fear, is the best remedy.

For a few years, all was quiet.

Ten years later, in 1978, Jack Levine was teaching delinquent kids at a short-term

he heard about the Dozier school.

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

One Sunday afternoon in November, Levine drove up to Health and Re... litative Services credentials. He found back of the campus. He could see a long hallway lined dark and reeked of body odor and urine.



Are there kids in here?

[Menu](#)

Tampa Bay Times



I want to meet one. How about this cell?

There were top and bottom slip locks and bolts. One lock wouldn't budge. The man went back to his desk, grabbed a book - the Holy Bible - and whacked the lock.

Inside on a concrete slab, not a mattress, Levine saw a very thin, small, frightened boy with a shaved head and pajama bottoms, no shirt.

How long have you been in here? Levine asked.

The boy shrugged.

He's been here for a while, the guard said.

The guard told Levine the boy was locked up for his own protection. The boy said the older boys were sodomizing him with a broom handle.

Why is his head shaved? Levine asked.

The boy has been pulling his hair out, the guard said.

Is he getting any help?

We just pass the food in.

own child advocate told his supervisor...
l Levine brought...
on "Bobby M" la...
students at Ma...na and two other state reform schoo...

The suit made a number of allegations, the most serious...
where boys were held for three weeks, sometimes longer. They were hogtied -
forced to lie on their stomachs with their wrists and ankles shackled together
behind their backs.



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



sharply reduce the population at Dozier and another juvenile institution. "These reforms launch Florida into a new and progressive era in the way we treat young offenders," HRS secretary Gregory Coler said at the time.

It didn't last.

In 1993, teenagers attacked two British tourists at a rest stop near Monticello, killing one. Already upset with increasingly violent youth, Floridians were in no mood to coddle young criminals. By 1994, Gov. Lawton Chiles asked a federal court to throw out the population caps at Dozier.

EDMUND D. FOUNTAIN | Times The Florida School for Boys did not have fences in the 1950's and 1960's. As a result, boys would frequently run away, but they were usually caught by guards, dogs or townspeople. Renamed the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys, the facility is ringed with a chain link fence and razor wire.

Juvenile justice rides the waves of public perception. Investigations bring outrage. Outrage brings promises of better funding and training, better monitoring, better checks and balances. Then the attention fades, and with it the reforms. In 1903,

early 80 years later, investigators

in lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

The school is still open, and still called the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys. It houses about 150 kids.



The state now makes available a telephone that children at the school can use to report abuse. The Department of Children and Families monitors those calls.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



or those were verified. Thirty-three had some indicator of legitimacy.

One incident was caught on security camera. Now it's on YouTube.

On Feb. 11, 2007, a skinny 18-year-old named Justin Caldwell is standing still in a dormitory at the school. A heavy-set guard approaches him and stands there for a moment. Then he grabs Caldwell by the throat and slams him backward on the ground. The guard drags the boy into the center of the room, his head bleeding, and leaves him. Caldwell looks to be unconscious. His legs twitch.

Two months later, the school's superintendent and a guard were fired. State officials decried operational problems at the school that "span the chain of command from top to bottom." The school's 200 employees would be trained to use verbal intervention instead of physical contact.

Again.

What is the cost to society of such a place? It's hard to know whether trauma at the Florida School for Boys set children on a course for violence. But one man knew that the school was harming kids: Lenox Williams, who took over as superintendent in 1966.

Williams for a 1968 story, "Hell's 1
as so understaffed
or sodomize oth

"I know some children are harmed by their experience
reporter. "But what can we do?"



Studies at the time showed that in facilities with fewer than 150 children, only 6 percent got into trouble and were sent back. Overcrowded Marianna had a

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



Many of the children who left the school in the 1950s and '60s went on to rape and rob and kill.

After 14 months at the school, Leon Holston killed three younger boys in Pompano Beach. He has been serving a life sentence in state prison since 1968. Roger Lee Cherry is facing execution for the 1986 murder of an elderly DeLand woman. Robert Hendrix is on death row for shooting a Sorrento man and slitting his wife's throat in 1991. Frank Smith died on death row.

Donn Duncan is serving life for the 1990 murder of his fiancée in the Orange County home they shared. He broke a knife off in the woman's back in front of her 13-year-old daughter. "I remember that place like it was yesterday," Duncan wrote in a letter to the Times.

The list goes on. Others have been in and out of prison their whole lives.

George Goewey has been arrested 38 times, most recently accused of cocaine possession and sale. He says he's clean now, and the 62-year-old has a stable job at a scooter shop in St. Petersburg, but he blames the school for ruining his life.

"You learned how to be sneaky," he says. "I lost all respect for authority."

Manuel Giddens was serving time in Marianna while his father was founding

to Tampa's homeless and building
ne Giddens got n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trum Read More
his release, he bi
in Fort Myers. n he started running marijuana and
through Miami and Fort Lauderdale, into Fort Myers i
and down the East Coast. He has been in and out of pr



"Marianna is the root of my whole problem," he says. "If I hadn't have been through that period of time, I would have took on my father's religion. I was born

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



Related story: [USF-led researchers to look for more graves at Florida reform school](#)

What about the others? How does childhood trauma manifest itself in law-abiding adults?

Robert Straley stopped leaving the house much when he nearly had a meltdown at a Wal-Mart. Roger Kiser is in his sixth marriage and still has trouble with hugs. Charles Rambo couldn't sleep in the dark until he was 25. James Griffin is 63 and still can't.

Jerry Cooper is 64 and takes Lexapro to calm his nerves. His wife once told him that the manager at the grocery store had asked for her number. Cooper drove to the store and waited in the parking lot. He walked to the man's car and punched through the window. It took five police officers to pull Cooper away.

"Even today I have a problem with authority," he says. "It has plagued me all my life."

Robert Lundy tried to drink the demons away. It cost him three marriages.

Michael O'McCarthy turned to alcohol, too, but the drinking led to paranoia and depression and self-loathing. Just a few years after Marianna, O'McCarthy tried to

... pretend gun. He spent seven years in ...

... n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

"We were childr

Bryant Middle earned a Purple Heart in Vietnam. If he'd go back to Marianna.



Eddie Horne sometimes has phantom pain. "I'll be laying in bed and I can feel the pain from where they beat me," he says. "I just want to go up there and make them pay."

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



From outward appearances, Stu Kruger has enjoyed good things in life. The 67-year-old worked on Wall Street and now runs a credit repair business in Miami. But he's never been able to stay put more than a year or two. He feels like someone is always after him.

"I've never told anybody this before," he says. He fishes into his pocket for something.

In Marianna, he and another boy had tried to run. They were marching back from the Saturday matinee in town, The Bridge on the River Kwai, when they tore off into the woods. They stole a car and peeled toward New York. But the state police caught them a mile or two out of town.

At the White House, the other boy went in first. Kruger sat in another room. As his friend screamed for his life, Kruger bent over and picked up a small pebble off the floor and rolled it in his fingers and thought about how small it was and how good it felt.

Fifty years and five marriages later, he pulls his hand out of his pocket. In his palm is a tiny pebble.

"I can't go anywhere without it," he says. "Fifty f----- years."

...a, pop. 6,200. ...n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

On weekends, ...ers chase white-tailed deer through
Preachers pack ...rches on Sunday mornings. Traffic
postcard main street slows to a crawl at 5 o'clock on we
at the First Baptist Church and the sun sets on a tall Confederate memorial
downtown.



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



Supercenter have sprung up around Exit 142, edging the city toward modern America.

Since the allegations of abuse were made public, some in town have pulled together to defend the school. They've suggested the White House Boys are exaggerating — even lying — and trying to milk money from the state. During a Chamber of Commerce breakfast, someone suggested the memorial plaque at the White House be removed. The local newspaper launched a series: "In Defense of Dozier."

Times files, March 1968 A St. Petersburg Times photograph shows a boy reading comics in bed next to a large hole in a wall patched with cardboard in the medical center of the Florida School for Boys in Marianna, FL. Governor Claude Kirk toured the facility that year and found it in deplorable condition, claiming "If one of your kids were kept in such circumstance, you'd be up there with rifles." Photographs accompanied a 1968 Times article entitled "Hell's 1400 Acres." [Times (1968)]

"Unfortunately, you can throw mud and dirt further than you can throw clean sand," wrote a columnist for the Jackson County Times. "These claims have not been proven or substantiated, but much national media attention has been

... the publicity for our community."

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

ong ago still live

Sammie West ^ outside town. He's 71 now.



West started at the school in 1960 and stayed for 40 years in a number of jobs including cottage father. He says he personally spanked two boys, and he administered fewer than 10 swats each. He even remembers their names. But that

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



"I do not know what went on behind closed doors," he says. "I would not say that there has never been a boy abused. It's going to happen. But I never saw it or heard about it. . . . I think they was spanked, and that's it."

He recalls three deaths at the school in his 40 years: A boy was found at the bottom of the swimming pool, a boy died from a heart condition in the gymnasium, and a boy drowned during a canoe trip on the Chipola River.

He says when the boys would run, he and other men were responsible for tracking them down, a task that often took hours. And a lot of boys ran before the campus was fenced in.

"Sometimes you'd go a month without boy hunting," he says. "And sometimes you'd go boy hunting every night."

Former Gov. Claude Kirk, now 83, remembers boys locked in their dorms at night with a chain. But he says he never heard about physical or sexual abuse. "None of that surfaced at the time," he says. "If it had, I would have done something about it. Put somebody in jail."

The men who were beaten say there's no way the abuse could have been kept secret. They say they sent photos of their behinds out with friends who were being released. Some told their families on visits, but things didn't change. Many needed

Some recall a Dr. Wexler smearin

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

Wexler is dead. His daughter remembers helping him with his eyesight, when their family lived on campus. Sheila Wexler treated boys who had cuts or welts on their behinds. "I don't know," she says, "it would only be a few."



Menu

Tampa Bay Times



radio is tuned to a Southern preacher. Inside, the walls are covered with antique farm implements and family photos. A framed certificate proclaims Williams a deacon at Trinity Baptist Church.

When he was hired as a psychologist in 1960, the school had a history of anemic funding. Buildings were falling apart. Mentally handicapped children shared the campus with 18-year-old sex offenders, because the state had no other place to send juvenile delinquents. The population swelled to more than 900 boys supervised by only 140 adults, which made keeping order a constant battle.

"There probably were some abuses," says Williams, who was superintendent from 1966 to 1986. "Anytime you've got human beings together, you're going to have people abusing each other."

Williams does not believe anyone was beaten to death. The old cemetery was there when he arrived. He ordered a Boy Scout troop to clean it up and fashion 31 new metal markers. He asked a Florida State graduate student to compile a history of the school and try to learn who was buried there.

The student found that the cemetery held six boys who died in the 1914 fire; 10 who died during an influenza epidemic in 1918; a boy who died after a prolonged illness in 1935; a runaway whose decomposed body was found under a private residence in Marianna in 1941; a boy found dead in the laundry after being beaten by another boy in 1949; two dogs and a peacock named Sue. He could account for

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

ers have been k

more sinister.



He says he has never seen a leather strap the men talk protocol to give 10 to 12 licks, depending on a boy's size.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



Williams may have a faulty memory. In 1997, he was deposed when former boys' school student Roger Lee Cherry appealed his death sentence.

"Was corporal punishment used at that time in 1962?" an attorney asked.

"Yes," Williams replied.

"Did that ever get out of hand?" the attorney asked.

"At times it did, yes."

Many boys sentenced to the school were severely abused by the staff in this building during the 1950's and 60's. [Photo courtesy of Roger D. Kiser]

A later superintendent, Roy McKay, who has died, offered a sworn statement for the same appeal.

"Although I never witnessed or participated in the strappings that were used as a

970s at Dozier, I did witness the a

asions, a child v [n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump](#) Read More

g beaten with a l

woodshed we c  d 'the White House.' "

In a later interview with the *Times*, Williams says he n 
 beatings before he was promoted to superintendent in 1966. He pauses over his
 grits. "I think there were some who might have enjoyed it on our staff," he says.
 "Might have enjoyed the over-spanking."

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



"We're trying to shield him as best we can," his landlord says on the phone. "He's an 85-year-old man."

"You're just trying to ruin a good man's life," says his ex-wife, Mary. "Leave him alone!"

Tidwell's granddaughter, Tiffany Pippin, says her family doubts the stories. They know a man who danced the fox-trot on Friday nights, who took his grandchildren fishing, who flirted with the ladies behind the perfume counter at the mall in Dothan, Ala. They know a man who always dressed sharp before he left the house and sat quiet in the First Baptist Church on Sunday mornings.

"He's a good man," says Pippin, 29. "He loved his wife. He never beat his children."

Tidwell's family lived in Bascom, a tiny town north of Marianna, Pippin says. His father died when he was young. When Troy Tidwell was 6, he played with his father's shotgun. He leaned on the barrel and accidentally fired the gun, which severed his left arm.

He's self-conscious about it and sits with his arm facing the wall when the family goes out to dinner. Pippin says her grandfather has worked hard his whole life to overcome the handicap, and after more than 40 years at the school he deserves a

allegations burn.

in lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

n of character,"

Times. "That's we are so upset about the lies and e
these men in an attempt for them to receive retribution



But she says neither her mother nor her uncle have asked Tidwell about the allegations. They respect him too much to ask.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



completely raise.

"He said, 'I never saw any child with bloody pants, bruised and bloody from being whipped. Certainly I never did it, and I can't imagine that anybody else did it either because I would have known about it.' "

How does that square with the stories?

"I don't know," Fuqua says. "I don't know whether they're lying, or the abuse that happened when they were a child was magnified over a time. All those kids, it was a bad situation they were here. Most of them were lonely and from broken homes. I don't know if it was magnified in their eyes. But the allegations of bloody underwear and that type of stuff, he just says didn't occur, or he was not aware of it occurring."

Bill Haynes is retiring after 30 years working for the Alabama Department of Corrections. He and his wife have a nice patch of land off a dirt road in a small town outside Montgomery. They live in a warm little brick house with a dachshund and a china cabinet full of glass Jesus figurines.

He's been having a hard time sleeping. His old nightmares are back. He dreams he is running through the swamp, dogs behind him. He wonders if he ever should

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

e a life of conver

you repay a man for years of distrust?



He wants reparations from the state, if it will make the



think twice before hitting a child. He'd like to see Arthur G. Dozier's name come off the school. He says he took a beating from Dozier himself, and that kind of sin should preclude the man from posthumous honor.

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



should have compassion for him.

He is told that Tidwell has been upset by the lawsuit, physically and emotionally, that it has disturbed what little life he has left. He stopped going to church. He hasn't been dancing. He asked his granddaughter if she would like to have his furniture.

Haynes is told that Tidwell can't sleep at night, and that he's alone, blinds drawn, scared to come out of his little white house.

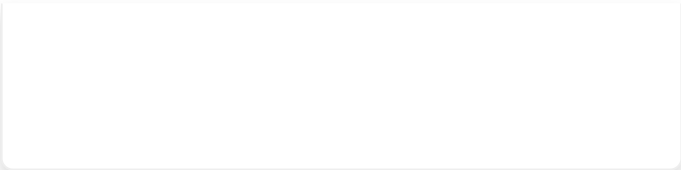
Maybe, he says, that's good enough.

Times researchers Caryn Baird and Will Gorham contributed to this report. This story was based on more than 100 hours of interviews with 27 men who were sent to the Florida School for Boys in the 1950s and '60s, and with current and former officials with the state, the school and the Department of Juvenile Justice. The interviews were supplemented with newspaper clippings, congressional and court testimony, archival photographs and other documents. Over five months, the reporters traveled to Marianna four times. Since launching its investigation, the Florida Department of Law Enforcement sealed access to the school, now called the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys. Through his attorney, Troy Tidwell declined to be interviewed.

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More



BEN MONTGOMERY
Times Correspondent



n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

Deadly Florida road co ^ ny knew workers were undocumented, ex-alleges

April 1

• Investigations



Menu

Tampa Bay Times

Investigations

ADVERTISEMENT

Florida eyes penalties for employers of undocumented migrants hurt on the job

Feb. 10

• Investigations

Florida state senator says he has a fix for dirty waters

Jan. 13

• Environment

6 ways Florida could start fixing its water pollution problems

Dec. 23, 2025

• Investigations

Federal officials end investigation into deadly Florida contractor

Dec. 17, 2025

• Investigations

DeSantis' agenda. your children's money | Column

n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump

Read More

Water pollution puts Floridians at risk of severe health problems

Dec. 17, 2025

• Investigations



Florida politicians call for action after Times report on deadly road contractor

Nov. 3, 2025

- Investigations



ADVERTISEMENT

ADVERTISEMENT

ADVERTISEMENT

Tampa Bay Times



n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More



Account

Digital access Home delivery Newsletters Manage my account Donate Subscriber FAQ

e-Newspaper FAQ e-Newspaper App FAQ

About

Times Publishing Company About us Connect with us Careers Community Guidelines

Advertise

Times Total Media Media Kit Place an ad Public Notices Classifieds Best of the Best



Shop

Champa Bay Shop Bucs Hardcover Book Lightning Hardcover Book Photo Reprints

Article Reprints Article Licensing Historic Front Pages Meeting Backgrounds

Podcasts

Archives

^

in lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump

Read More

Sponsored Conte

Menu

Tampa Bay Times



n lose': Catholic leaders decry Trump Read More

